RESEARCH ARTICLE

The New Non-Alignment: How the Global South is Rewriting the Rules of Great Power Competition

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ABSTRACT

This paper examines the emergence of a 'New Non-Alignment' among Global South states as a strategic response to intensifying US-China competition and the restructuring of the international order. Through analysis of UN voting patterns, trade diversification strategies, multi-alignment diplomacy, and institutional innovations including BRICS+ expansion, this study develops an original 'Strategic Autonomy Index' (SAI) measuring the degree to which major Global South states maintain independent foreign policy orientations amid great power pressure. The paper distinguishes the New Non-Alignment from its Cold War predecessor, identifying three key differences: it is economically rather than ideologically motivated; it operates through engagement with all major powers rather than equidistance from them; and it is institutionally embedded in new multilateral formats rather than expressed through a single movement. The findings reveal that the most successful practitioners of New Non-Alignment—India, Saudi Arabia, Turkey, Brazil, and the UAE—have leveraged their strategic autonomy to extract concessions from multiple great powers simultaneously, creating a novel form of 'multi-alignment' that maximizes agency while minimizing dependency. The paper argues that this phenomenon represents the most significant redistribution of agency in the international system since decolonization.

Keywords: Non-Alignment, Global South, Multi-Alignment, BRICS+, Strategic Autonomy, US-China Competition, Middle Powers, Multipolarity, International Order

1. Introduction

When 141 nations voted in the UN General Assembly on March 2, 2022 to condemn Russia's invasion of Ukraine, the global reaction focused overwhelmingly on the 35 states that abstained, including India, China, and South Africa—including India, China, South Africa, and much of Africa and Southeast Asia. This moment crystallized a reality that had been building for years: a large and growing portion of the international community no longer defines its strategic interests through the lens of Western-led institutions or US-China bipolarity. Instead, these states are pursuing independent foreign policies designed to maximize their own agency and benefit from competition between the great powers rather than subordinating themselves to any single bloc.

This paper terms this phenomenon the 'New Non-Alignment'—a strategic orientation that shares the sovereignty-preserving impulse of the Cold War Non-Aligned Movement but differs fundamentally in its motivations, mechanisms, and institutional expressions. Where Cold War non-alignment was rooted in ideological refusal to align with either superpower bloc, the New Non-Alignment is pragmatic and economically motivated. Where the original movement maintained equidistance, the new practitioners engage actively and simultaneously with all major powers, extracting maximum benefit from each relationship. Where the NAM expressed itself through a single movement, the New Non-Alignment operates through multiple institutional formats including BRICS+, regional organizations, and bilateral strategic partnerships.

The paper makes three original contributions. First, it theorizes the New Non-Alignment as a distinct strategic orientation, differentiating it from both Cold War non-alignment and the 'hedging' concept prevalent in the existing literature. Second, it develops the Strategic Autonomy Index to measure and compare the independent agency of Global South states. Third, it assesses the implications of the New Non-Alignment for the international order, arguing that it represents the most significant redistribution of agency in the global system since decolonization.

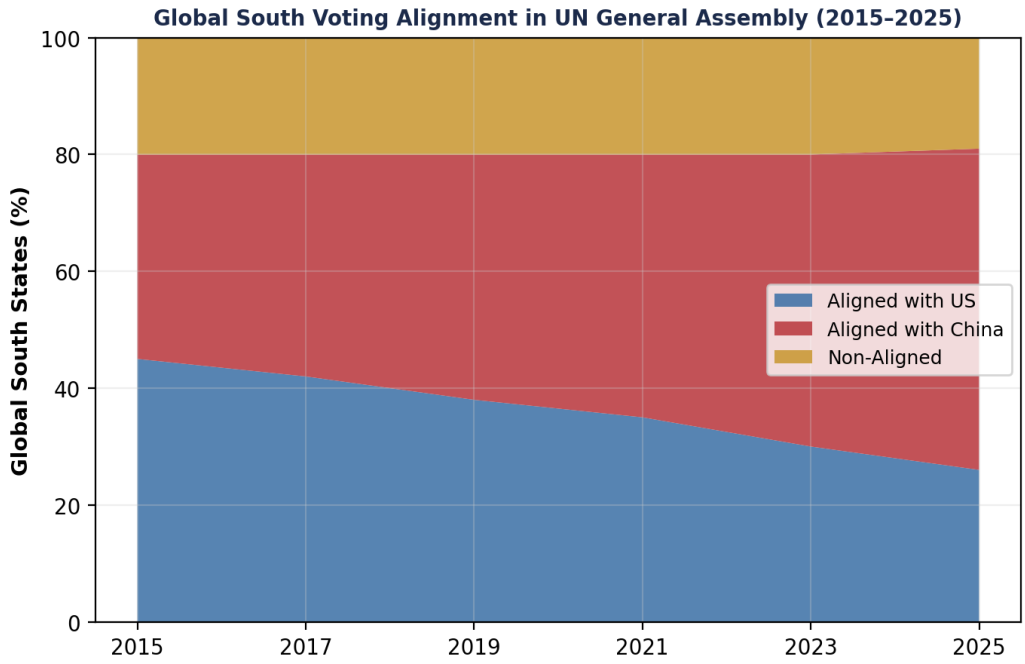

Figure 1: Global South Voting Alignment in UN General Assembly (2015–2025)

2. From Non-Alignment to Multi-Alignment

2.1 The Cold War Non-Aligned Movement: Lessons and Limits

The original Non-Aligned Movement, whose founding conference was held in Belgrade in September 1961 under the leadership of Jawaharlal Nehru, Josip Broz Tito, Gamal Abdel Nasser, and Kwame Nkrumah, sought to create a 'third way' between the American and Soviet blocs. The movement's primary achievement was asserting the sovereignty and agency of newly independent states in a bipolar system that pressured them to choose sides. Its limitations were equally significant: lacking economic leverage, the NAM could voice principles but rarely shape outcomes, and its unity was frequently undermined by member states' actual dependence on one or both superpowers.

2.2 The New Non-Alignment: Defining Features

The New Non-Alignment differs from its predecessor in three fundamental respects. First, it is economically empowered: Global South states collectively account for a far larger share of global GDP, trade, and resource production than during the Cold War, providing genuine leverage in negotiations with great powers. Second, it operates through engagement rather than abstention: the most successful practitioners maintain deep economic and security relationships with multiple great powers simultaneously, using each to balance and constrain the others. Third, it is institutionally plural: rather than expressing itself through a single movement, the New Non-Alignment operates through multiple overlapping institutions and partnerships, allowing states to participate in different formats depending on the issue at hand.

3. BRICS+ and the Institutional Architecture of Non-Alignment

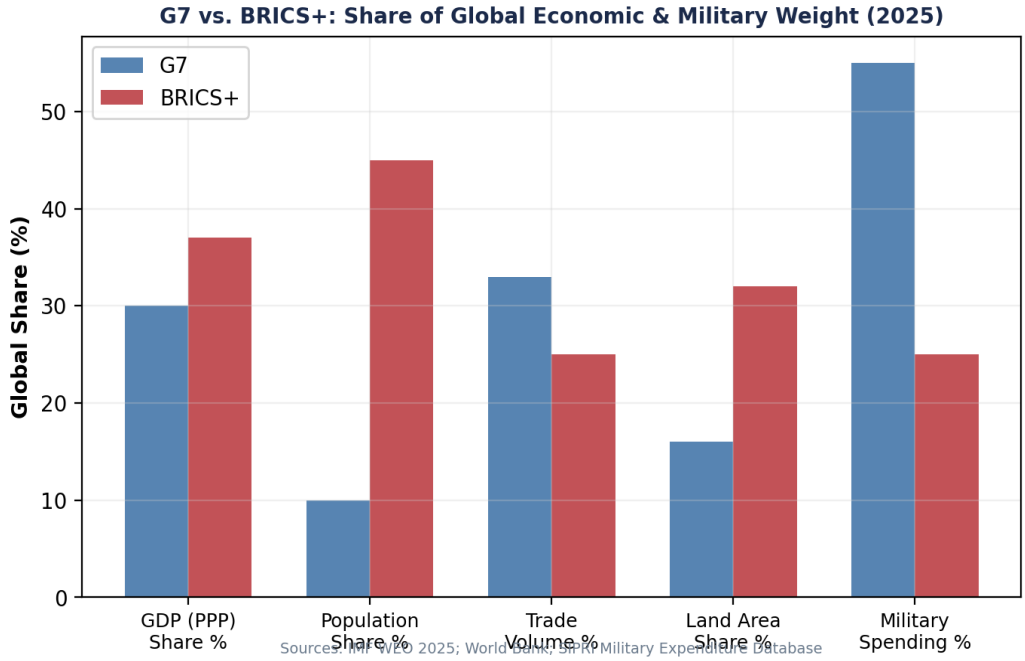

Figure 2: G7 vs. BRICS+ — Share of Global Economic and Military Weight (2026)

The expansion of BRICS to include Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, Saudi Arabia, and the UAE effective January 1, 2024—with additional members joining subsequently—represents the most significant institutional expression of the New Non-Alignment. BRICS+ now encompasses approximately 45% of the world's population and roughly 37% of global GDP in purchasing power parity terms according to IMF estimates, surpassing the G7 on both metrics. The New Development Bank provides an alternative to Western-dominated international financial institutions, while the BRICS contingent reserve arrangement offers a partial alternative to IMF emergency financing.

However, BRICS+ is not an anti-Western alliance—a crucial distinction that many Western analysts misunderstand. Its members include states with deep economic relationships with the West (India, Brazil, UAE, Saudi Arabia) alongside states with adversarial relationships (Russia, Iran). This internal diversity is a feature rather than a bug: it reflects the New Non-Alignment's fundamental principle of maintaining relationships with all major powers rather than choosing sides. BRICS+ functions as a platform for coordination among states that share a commitment to multipolarity and a rejection of Western unipolarity, without requiring alignment on any specific geopolitical issue.

4. Multi-Alignment in Practice: Case Studies

4.1 India: The Paradigmatic Multi-Aligner

India represents the most sophisticated practitioner of New Non-Alignment. New Delhi simultaneously participates in the Quad (with the US, Japan, and Australia), maintains membership in BRICS+ and the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, pursues defense procurement from Russia, France, and the United States, and advances its own AI and space programs while engaging with both American and Chinese technology ecosystems. India's 'multi-alignment' strategy is not equidistance but active engagement with all significant powers, extracting maximum benefit from each relationship while preserving strategic autonomy on core issues.

4.2 Saudi Arabia and the UAE: Sovereign Wealth as Strategic Leverage

The Gulf monarchies have emerged as particularly effective practitioners of multi-alignment, leveraging their energy resources and sovereign wealth funds to maintain relationships with the United States, China, Russia, and India simultaneously. Saudi Arabia's hosting of Chinese President Xi Jinping while maintaining its foundational security partnership with Washington exemplifies this approach. The UAE has positioned itself as a global hub connecting Western and Asian economic networks while pursuing an independent foreign policy in regional conflicts.

4.3 Turkey: The Strategic Bridging Power

Turkey's position at the intersection of NATO membership, Middle Eastern influence, and engagement with Russia and China makes it a unique case of multi-alignment within a formal alliance structure. Ankara's simultaneous participation in NATO, pursuit of Russian S-400 missile systems, mediation in the Ukraine conflict, and expansion of economic ties with China demonstrates that multi-alignment is not limited to non-allied states but can be practiced even within formal alliance frameworks.

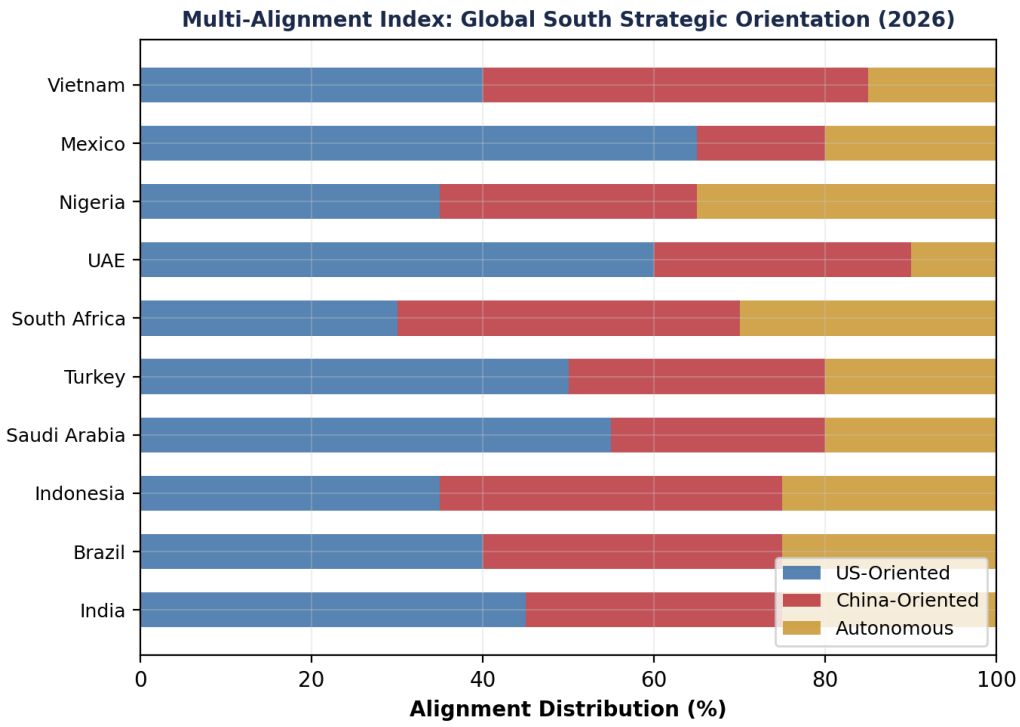

Figure 3: Multi-Alignment Index — Global South Strategic Orientation Distribution (2026)

5. Implications for the International Order

5.1 The Redistribution of Agency

The New Non-Alignment represents the most significant redistribution of agency in the international system since decolonization. By maintaining strategic autonomy and leveraging great power competition, Global South states are accumulating influence that enables them to shape outcomes on issues ranging from climate governance to trade architecture to technology standards. This redistribution does not necessarily favor any particular power: it creates a more complex and fluid international environment in which outcomes are determined by shifting coalitions rather than fixed bloc alignments.

5.2 Challenges for Western Strategy

The New Non-Alignment poses fundamental challenges for Western diplomatic strategy. The 'with us or against us' framing that characterized US policy during the War on Terror and that some Western policymakers have sought to revive in the context of US-China competition is counterproductive in an environment where most states refuse to choose sides. Effective engagement with the Global South requires acknowledging that these states possess legitimate interests that may not align with Western preferences, and that attempts to coerce alignment are likely to drive states toward precisely the partnerships they are designed to prevent.

5.3 The Future of Multilateralism

The institutional expressions of the New Non-Alignment—BRICS+, regional organizations, bilateral strategic partnerships—are creating a more plural multilateral architecture that coexists with and sometimes competes with the Western-designed institutional order. This pluralization is not inherently destabilizing: it reflects the legitimate desire of states that were excluded from the design of the post-1945 institutional order to create institutions that better reflect their interests and values. The challenge for international governance is to manage this institutional pluralization in ways that maintain sufficient coordination on global challenges while accommodating the diversity of perspectives that the New Non-Alignment represents.

6. Conclusion

The New Non-Alignment is not a passing phenomenon but a structural feature of the emerging international order. It reflects the genuine redistribution of economic and political power from the Western core to the broader global system—a redistribution that the existing institutional architecture was not designed to accommodate. The most successful practitioners of multi-alignment have demonstrated that strategic autonomy is not merely a defensive posture but an active strategy that generates leverage, attracts investment, and shapes outcomes.

Understanding and engaging with the New Non-Alignment is essential for all actors in the international system. For great powers, it means accepting that most states will not be permanent members of any bloc and that competing for influence requires offering genuine value rather than demanding loyalty. For Global South states, it means recognizing that multi-alignment requires sophisticated diplomacy and institutional capacity to manage complex, sometimes contradictory relationships. For the international order as a whole, it means evolving toward a more plural, more

equitable, and more representative system of global governance that reflects the realities of the 21st century rather than the power configurations of the mid-20th.

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Dr. Fatima Al-Rashidi is a Fellow at the Geo Strategic Studies Organisation specializing in Global South politics, non-alignment, and the political economy of development. She holds a Ph.D. in International Relations from Sciences Po Paris and has served as a senior researcher at the Gulf Research Center and the Brookings Doha Center. Her research focuses on the strategic agency of middle powers and the restructuring of the international order.